



False memories

When a memory is reconsolidated, new information is stored with old. But when we next recall the memory, it is impossible to tell which is which. This means we can end up with false memories. Just talking about an event can change our memory of it, so in legal cases, witnesses must be questioned carefully, to avoid contaminating their memories.

WHAT IS DÉJÀ VU?

The feeling of déjà vu might arise because we recognize something in an environment but cannot recall what. This gives a vague feeling of familiarity.

VACATIONS



BIRTHDAYS



1 True memory

Scientists asked participants to watch clips of car accidents. After each clip, they had to describe what happened and answer questions. This meant they were recalling and reactivating the memory.



2 New information

Some participants were asked about the cars' speed when they "contacted" each other, while others were asked about the speed when the cars "smashed." The first group rated the cars as slower than the second group.



TIME LATER

NEW INFORMATION
STORED WITH OLD

3 False memory recalled

One week later, subjects recalled the video again and were asked whether there was any broken glass (there was not). Significantly more people in the "smashed" group "remembered" broken glass. The words used had changed their memory of the event.



RECALL VERSUS RECOGNITION

It is much easier to recognize something as familiar when we are shown it than it is to recall the details without any input. For example, we all know what a quarter looks like, but could you draw one from memory?

